



TURKMENISTAN

Capital city: Ashgabat
Area: 188,455 sq miles (488,100 sq km)
Population: 4,900,000
Official language: Turkmen
Major religions: Muslim 87%, Christian 11%, other 2%
Government: Presidential dictatorship
Currency: Manat
Adult literacy rate: 98%
Life expectancy: 65 years
People per doctor: 382

KYRGYZSTAN

Capital city: Bishkek
Area: 76,640 sq miles (198,500 sq km)
Population: 5,100,000
Official language: Kyrgyz, Russian
Major religions: Muslim 72%, Christian and other 28%
Government: Democracy
Currency: Som
Adult literacy rate: 97%
Life expectancy: 65 years
People per doctor: 385

TURKMENISTAN

ALMOST 90 PERCENT of Turkmenistan consists of the vast Kara Kum ("Black Sands") Desert, where temperatures reach more than 122°F (50°C). A fertile strip of land stretches around the southern borders of the desert; here people grow cotton and other crops for export. Since Turkmenistan became independent in 1991, Turkmen has replaced Russian as the state language, and Islam is once again the major religion. The country is poor and isolated from the rest of the world, but possesses huge reserves of natural gas.



THE TURKMENS

The Turkmen people live in various parts of central Asia and many follow a nomadic lifestyle. In Turkmenistan, however, many Turkmen have settled as farmers and expert horse breeders. They visit local horse fairs and buy and sell horses for export to neighboring countries. The Turkmen are known for producing prized racehorses, such as the Akhal-Teke, a breed able to move quickly in desert conditions.



ASHGABAT

In 1948, the bustling market town of Ashgabat was totally destroyed by a huge earthquake. The town was completely replanned and rebuilt, and is now the capital city of Turkmenistan. Ashgabat is a center for food processing and silk, lace, and carpet manufacturing.



KARAKUM CANAL
 The world's longest irrigation canal stretches from the Amu Darya River in the east to beyond Ashgabat in the west, a distance of 683 miles (1,100 km). Known as the "River of Life," the Karakum Canal provides water for a large area of arid land so that cotton and other crops can be grown.

KYRGYZSTAN

KNOWN AS THE Switzerland of central Asia because of its mountainous landscape, over half of Kyrgyzstan is 8,200 ft (2,500 m) or more above sea level. The snowcapped Tien Shan Mountains dominate the countryside, but the river valleys are fertile and green. Most people are farmers. Animal breeding is particularly important because there is so little land to farm.

THE KYRGYZ PEOPLE

The population is more than half native Kyrgyz. These nomadic people are known for their skilled horsemanship. The largest minority group are Russians, who live in the towns and, until independence in 1991, ran the economy. As a result of rising nationalist feeling among the Kyrgyz, many Russian people have now returned to Russia.

The Kyrgyz people practice Islam. They speak a Turkic language and live a nomadic life in the countryside.



MOUNTAIN RICHES

The mountains of Kyrgyzstan are rich in minerals. Gold and mercury are mined for export, while coal, oil, and gas are exploited for domestic use. The fast-flowing rivers are ideal for generating electricity, and new hydroelectric power plants have been built.

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